



Sizzling southpaw: Axar Patel was India's second-highest run-scorer in the last Border-Gavaskar Trophy against Australia, played on raging turners, and topped the charts with a batting average of 88. K.R. DEEPAK

batters emerged as saviours. Axar was India's second-highest run-scorer in the Border-Gavaskar Trophy against Australia, played on raging turners, and topped the charts with a batting average of 88. Meanwhile, in the series against England, Jadeja and Axar averaged 38.66 and 33.25, respectively, significantly higher than specialist batters Iyer (26), Rajat Patidar (10.50), and wicketkeeper K. S. Bharat (23.00).

A cursory glance at batting averages for those who have played a minimum of 10 matches at home since 2021 further attests that lower-order rescue missions are not intermittent or miraculous instances.

Jadeja has the second highest average (44.00) at home during this period, bettered only marginally by Shubman Gill (44.90). Axar (39.60) is fourth on this list, above Virat Kohli (32.05), while Ashwin (26.44) tops an out-of-favour Cheteshwar Pujara (24.53).

India's lower-order, which entails batting positions 7, 8, and 9, has been doing the heavy-lifting largely owing to the middle-order's (positions 4, 5 and 6) dwindling returns. Since 2020, in Tests in India, the lower-order has contributed 23.91 per cent of the total runs scored, up from 14.48 per cent between 2016 and 2019, while the middle order's share has fallen from 39.68 per cent in 2016-19 to 32.53 per cent between 2020 and now. Alarming, the middle-order's average has plummeted from a whopping 60.78 in the 2016-19 period to 34.34 between 2020-24, and is now comparable to the lower order's 31.92 in the corresponding period. Meanwhile, the top order

(positions 1, 2 and 3) has also seen a sharp decline in averages, dropping from 55.61 in 2016-19 to 43.03 in 2020-24.

Between the periods 2016-19 and 2020-24, the top six batting positions have all witnessed a steep decline in averages in home Tests, with the No. 4 spot suffering the sharpest drop — from 82.06 to 29.80. This drastic fall coincides with No. 4 mainstay Kohli's dip in form, whose average has shrunk from 86.35 to 33.16 in that position at home between the corresponding periods. Interestingly, India's No. 7 (38.47) and 8 (36.78) boast of a higher average than No. 4 (29.80) and 5 (33.86) since 2020 in home games.

The No. 5 position, earlier held by Ajinkya Rahane, is likely to see some stability with the return of Rishabh Pant and the emergence of Sarfaraz Khan, after Iyer's unsuccessful bid for the spot.

The recent struggles of the middle-order, that have necessitated